each to the company. For example, you might say: “I saved the company $20,000 this year by researching and negotiating contracts with new vendors.”

Determine the Going Rate for Your Job

Next, you need to determine the going rate, both inside and outside the company, for what you do. Ask your company’s human resources department if there are company-wide salary ranges for your position and several related positions above yours. Review these, along with the salary information and compensation surveys you obtained from the BLS website. National information can give you an idea of what jobs similar to yours typically pay, but salaries vary from one region to another. Be sure to consult some local information as well by reading help-wanted ads, talking to friends and associates, or making a call to your local human resources organization, such as the Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM; *www.shrm.org*).

Know Your Company’s Policies and Financial Status

To increase your chances of getting the raise you want, you need to know several things about your company. What is the company’s financial condition? Is it struggling to stay afloat? Is there a budget crisis? What is the policy on salary increases? Are all employees reviewed at the same time each year? Does your department have a budget for salaries that it needs to stay within? If so, you’re in direct competition with the other employees in your department for limited funds, and you should work on making yourself stand out above the crowd.

Pick Your Time Carefully

Timing is everything. If you’ve only been at your job for a few months, asking for a raise probably won’t go over very well. However, if you find after a few months that the company hired you at a salary well below that of others in your position and with your experience, it may pay to discuss this with your supervisor. If you’ve been formally or informally disciplined or chastised recently, wait at least a few months before asking for more money.